

WORKSHEET — PARASHAH NITZAVIM/VAYELECH

Appendix A (filled in) · The Frame for parashah study · a teaching tool

How to use this sheet

Work from top to bottom: first observe (A1), then weigh (A2), then diagnose (A3), and only then summarize (A4). The direction — received or grasped — is the horizon, not the starting point.

Basic details

→ First fill in the basics: which passage, which haftarah, any flanking reading with its status, and for whom you are making this.

Parashah / delimitation: Nitzavim/Vayelech — Deuteronomy 29:10–31:30

Haftarah / ritual place: Isaiah 61:10–63:9 (seventh comfort sabbath; sheva de-nechemta)

Flanking reading and status: John 12:41–50 — New Testament mirroring, confessionally used (not as peshat).

Target group and desired form: Study group / congregation · a compact study and a spoken reading.

A1. Text blocks and peshat

→ Read block by block. Note first what it says, then the key word or contrast, and only then a genuine open question.

Text block	What does it say? (peshat)	Key words / contrast	Open question
29:10-14	All stand present, from head to water-drawer, to enter into the covenant and its oath; God confirms them as a people — also on behalf of the one 'not here today'.	stepping in · covenant beyond the generation · head to water-drawer	Who enters here, and on whose behalf?
29:15-28	The root bearing poison is the person who secretly bléssees himself (29:18). Wrath, exile. Then 29:29: the secret things belong to the LORD; the revealed to us and our children, 'to do them'.	hidden ↔ revealed · self-blessing · to do	Why is the secret precisely the root?
30:1-10	After exile: return (teshuvah), God gathers, and God circumcises the heart (30:6) to love Him.	return · God circumcises · heart freed	What comes first: the freed heart, or the loving?
30:11-14	The commandment is not too wondrous, not far, not in heaven, not over the sea — near, in mouth and heart, 'to do it' (3× la'asoto; 4QDeut-b/LXX add 'and in your hands').	near · in mouth / heart / hands · to do	What does 'near' mean — non-committal, or reachable-to-do?
30:15-20	'I have set before you life and death, blessing and cursing — choose life.' Heaven and earth as witnesses.	choose · life / death · witnesses	Why is the choice laid with the human?
31:1-30	Moses (120) hands over to Joshua ('be strong and of good courage', 31:7); the	handover · read aloud · witness	Why does passing on belong with the near word?

Text block	What does it say? (peshat)	Key words / contrast	Open question
	Torah read aloud every seven years to the whole people incl. children and stranger (31:11-12); the song and the Torah beside the ark, as witness.		

A2. Connecting hypotheses

→ Formulate two readings the text could carry, and choose with the test: which explains the most data with the least force?

Hypothesis 1 (one axis): the center of gravity is the Source axis alone — the parashah is grace: God gathers, circumcises the heart (30:6), makes it reachable. The doing then stays secondary.

Hypothesis 2 (relation): the center of gravity is the relation — the near word is brought near (Source) precisely to be done and passed on (Will/Coherence). 30:6 is the ground, 30:11-20 + all of Vayelech the mass.

Which explains the most data with the least force? Hypothesis 2. Hypothesis 1 sees the grace, but makes the rhetorical mass (3× 'to do it', 'choose', all of Vayelech with the handover) inexplicable. The relation reading grounds the doing in the given nearness.

What would refute this reading? If 30:6 (the circumcised heart) stood as climax and 30:11-20 functioned as a subclause, the center of gravity would lie with Source / receiving. The text turns that around — 30:6 is precondition, not landing place.

A3. Four axes

→ Fill in the text anchors and a short diagnosis per axis. Leave the last column for what your reading does not smooth over.

Axis	Text anchors	Diagnosis	Open anomaly
Will	29:11 (stepping in) · 30:2 (returning/doing) · 30:11-14 (near doing) · 30:19 (choosing) · 31:7,12 (handing over, hearing-learning-doing)	Bearing. Answer within reach; the word is brought to you — no self-sufficiency, yet a real calling.	Where does 'chosen doing' turn into 'my own strength' (cf. 8:17)?
Coherence	29:18 (secret self-blessing) · 29:29 (hidden ↔ revealed, to do) · 31:19 (song as witness)	Bearing, second pole. No gap between hidden heart and public deed; arvut — the people stand surety as one body.	The nekudot on 'us and our children' — why a mark on precisely the passed-on responsibility?
Source	30:3-6 (God gathers, circumcises the heart)	Real, but does not carry the weight here — ground, not climax. The freed heart makes the doing reachable.	Why does 30:6 stand before, and not as landing place?
Trajectory	exile → return (30:1-5) · Moses → Joshua (31:7) · generation → generation (31:12-13)	Rising; feeds the 'passing on' side, but serves Will, not as a core of its own.	Is 'for ever' (29:29) a limit, or a promise?

Reactivity: the reflex puts the weight on receiving / defencelessness (30:6 as climax) — precisely what the sources contradict. Note it as watch, and do not place it as the motor under the reading.

A4. Movement

→ Summarize the movement: what does the text unmask, what frame does it put in its place, what response follows — and capture it in one core sentence.

What is unmasked? The word made far away — in heaven, over the sea, a burden, a yoke imposed (or making yourself a badge); and the person who in secret blesses himself and yet walks his own way (29:18).

What frame does the text put in its place? The near word: God circumcises the heart (30:6) and brings the word into your mouth, heart and hands (30:11-14) — reachable to be done, and to be passed on.

What concrete response and formation follow? Step into the covenant; choose life; read the word aloud and lay it in your child's hand (31:11-12); and the self-test — do I do out of received nearness, or do I grasp and secretly bless myself?

Core sentence: The word is not far — God brought it near and freed the heart; so step in, choose, do it, and pass it on.

Horizon (not this week's theme, but the ground): beneath all this lies received or grasped. The near-word-to-do is the received-form; the secret self-blessing the grasped-form. In the gospel the near word becomes a Person (John 12): a Mouth that speaks 'not of Itself', the Light that came to us.